

BoxdIn - Version 1 Review

Overview of BoxdIn

BoxdIn pulls data from a Letterboxd user's public RSS feed, adds some extra details from IMDB's API (like genre, director,IMDb rating), and then prints out some fun stats and insights based on all of that.

So far, I've built the parts that grab the RSS feed, pull in the extra movie data, save everything to a CSV file so it doesn't have to look everything up again next time. It produces four different sets of insights: a 30 day snapshot, a look at variety (genres, directors, years), a rating breakdown, and a rating histogram. All of this is still command line based in VSCode.

Demo

Screenshots below are from running BoxdIn on my friend Chloe's account (username protocrone), the guinea pig for testing all semester.

- Terminal shows "Loaded existing data for protocrone" up top. That's the CSV caching. It skipped OMDb since her data was already saved from a past run.
- Snapshot: 0 films watched, 0.0 hours, genre N/A. Chloe just hasn't logged anything the last 30 days.
- Variety: 20 unique genres, 43 unique directors, oldest film from 1938, newest from 2026. She's got range!
- Rating Breakdown: average rating by genre, director, and decade (minimum 3 films must have been logged in ant of those categories). It compares her ratings to IMDb's average. It also highlights her "most controversial opinion" (the movie with the biggest gap between her rating and IMDb's).
- Rating Graph: this is technically called a histogram, and shows how many films landed at each star rating from 0.5 to 5.0.

```
PS C:\Users\shawn\Documents\HCI Program - ISU\HCI 584 - Class File>
Loaded existing data for protocrone
--- Snapshot: Your Last 30 Days ---
Films watched: 0
Hours watched: 0.0
Most watched genre: N/A
--- Variety ---
Unique genres watched: 20
Unique directors watched: 43
Oldest film release year: 1938
Newest film release year: 2026
--- Rating Breakdown ---
Average rating by genre (min. 3 films):
  Drama: 3.8
  Music: 3.33
  Thriller: 3.39
  Comedy: 3.73
  Biography: 3.3
  History: 3.62
  Adventure: 3.82
  Action: 3.62
  Romance: 3.92
  Crime: 3.89
  Horror: 4.1
  Mystery: 4.0
  Fantasy: 3.7
Average rating by director (min. 3 films):
  Peter Jackson: 4.33
  Alfred Hitchcock: 4.62
Average rating by decade (min. 3 films):
  2000s: 4.08
  2010s: 3.69
  2020s: 3.5
```

```
Your ratings vs IMDb:
Woah! Your average ratings match IMDb EXACTLY!
Most controversial opinion: Marty Supreme
  You rated it: 1.0 | IMDb average: 3.85
--- Rating Graph ---
  0.5 stars: 0
  1.0 stars: 1
  1.5 stars: 1
  2.0 stars: 3
  2.5 stars: 4
  3.0 stars: 7
  3.5 stars: 5
  4.0 stars: 13
  4.5 stars: 9
  5.0 stars: 7
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```

Issues That Arose

- Early on, the app would crash with an error whenever a film was missing some info from the RSS feed. I found out it was because I was trying to grab data in a way that only works if every field is there. I switched to a different way of grabbing the data that just skips it if something's missing instead of crashing.

Issues Not Yet Solved

- The saving part doesn't work exactly how I wanted. Right now, if there's already a saved file for someone in the CSV file, the app just uses that and doesn't check OMDb for anything new. If there's no saved file yet, it checks OMDb for every single film which takes several minutes to return. What I actually wanted was for it to only check OMDb for the new films that aren't already saved.
- If someone types in a username that doesn't exist, the app will crash instead of telling them to try again. Right now it's set to always use the same test username, so this hasn't actually happened, but it would be a problem if someone typed something wrong.
- One thing to keep in mind for later: sometimes there might be two movies with the same title (like Planet of the Apes 1968 or 2001), and the app might grab info for the wrong one by mistake. I haven't actually seen this happen yet, just something I want to keep an eye on.

Where Help Is Needed

- Nothing is stopping me from finishing right now. If I had to guess what would be hardest to fix, it's probably that last point. Making sure the app picks the right movie when there's more than one with the same name.

Milestones for the Future

- Clean up the code: go through main.py and organize it better, remove any leftover test code, and make sure the file names and folders make sense.
- Fix the API key setup: right now the OMDb key is typed directly into the code, which I was told to do for grading.
- Write a requirements file: a file that lists all the outside tools (like feedparser and pandas)
- Write a user's guide and a programmer's guide
- Record a demo video: a short video showing the app running and explaining what it does, for the final project presentation.

Self Reflection

I am satisfied with my progress so far. This semester has been a lot. I had a baby, I'm working full time, and I'm also taking care of my one year old, so finding time to work on this has been hard. I ran out of time and never fully caught up. I'm really thankful Professor Harding has been understanding about deadlines this semester, since without that flexibility I wouldn't have been able to get even this far. But this was a pretty intimidating project for me, and the fact that I was able to build this is something I'm actually really proud of. I plan to finish it on my own time and make it into something I can share with my friends.

I'm submitting the version 1 deliverables here as we finish up the course, and letting go of version 2, which was building the actual web interface and turning this into a usable app. Once I get these version 1 deliverables in, I'm moving to the final submission deliverables and putting those together using what I have now.

Expectations vs. reality: the RSS feed part went about how I expected, since we'd already worked with that kind of thing in HCI 574. The OMDb API and the CSV saving system were harder than I thought going in, and I didn't get the caching logic fully working the way I originally planned. That one's still on my list.

Light bulb moment: I didn't expect to end up adding the Rating Histogram section. It wasn't part of my original plan, but once I was working on the rating breakdown stuff, it just made sense to add it, and it turned out to be one of my favorite parts of the app.